Research Methods Comparison

Class Practical | Paper 2 Preparation – First Assessment 2027

Name: _____ Date: _____

Instructions: Compare the research method used in your completed practical with a different method that could investigate the same psychological topic. Use specific details from your practical and explain how changing the research method would affect the investigation. Write your answers in your notebook.

Practical topic: _____

Original research method:

_____

Alternative research method:

_____

Part 1 – Comparing Research Methods

1. Research Aim

What was the aim of your original practical? Could the alternative method investigate exactly the same question, or would the aim need to change?

Example: An interview could explore how students experience stress, whereas an observation could investigate specific behaviours during study sessions. Both concern stress, but they investigate different aspects of it.

2. Research Procedure

How was your original investigation conducted? How would the procedure change if you used the alternative method?

Include: What participants would do, what researchers would do, how information would be collected, and what level of control researchers would have.

3. Sample and Sampling

Who participated in your original practical, and how were they recruited? Would the alternative method require a different sample or sampling procedure?

Think about: Whether participants need particular characteristics, how easily they could be recruited, and whether the sampling method might affect the findings.

4. Data and Findings

What type of data did your original method collect? What type of data could the alternative method collect, and how might this change what researchers could conclude?

Example: An interview might provide detailed accounts of participants' experiences, while a structured observation could record how frequently particular behaviours occur.

Explain what each method could reveal that the other might not. Do not invent findings for the alternative investigation.

Part 2 – Evaluating the Methods

5. Strengths and Limitations

Identify one important strength and one limitation of **each method** in relation to your research topic.

For each, explain how it could affect the quality of the evidence or the conclusions researchers could draw.

Think about: Researcher control, bias, depth of information, accuracy of measurement, ecological validity and the ability to investigate causality.

Example: An interview may provide detailed explanations of personal experiences but may be affected by social desirability bias. An observation records behaviour directly but cannot necessarily establish what participants are thinking.

6. Ethical Considerations

Identify one ethical consideration that applies to both methods and one ethical challenge that might differ between them.

Explain how each issue would be addressed.

Example: Both methods require appropriate protection of participant information, but an observation in a public setting may raise different privacy concerns from a private interview.

Part 3 – Paper 2 Comparison Practice

7. Compare and Contrast

Using your answers above, write a short examination-style response:

Compare and contrast the research method used in your class practical with your chosen alternative method.

Your response should include:

- Two clearly explained differences.
- One meaningful similarity.
- Accurate psychological terminology.
- Specific examples from your practical or proposed alternative.

Writing guidance: Organise your answer around points of comparison, such as researcher control or data collection. For each point, explain both methods and why the similarity or difference matters.

Avoid describing the two methods separately without directly comparing them.